

Figure 5: M.V. Maya Nadar (a marble carving)

M.V. Maya Nadar (Figure 5), the sole ‘lower’ caste[58] director of the company dropped off sometime between January and August 1907.[59] Hailing from the nearby trading town of Aruppukkottai, Maya Nadar’s family had moved to Tuticorin in the 1870s. The family firm was involved in banking, doubling up as commission agents and merchants. Maya Nadar was born probably in the 1870s and died in 1915. It appears that he felt alienated from SSNCo; and though he subscribed to more than a hundred shares, he did not pay the full capital despite repeated calls from the company. A loyalist deputy magistrate, Diravia Nadar, based in Tuticorin, dissuaded Christian Nadars from taking part in the Swadeshi movement and investing in SSNCo, warning them that it would deprive the community of their hard-won rights and social mobility.[60] He seems to have met with some success. Though a Hindu, not only did Maya Nadar leave the company, one Sankaralinga Nadar, swayed by such arguments, confronted VOC. VOC’s reassurances left him unconvinced.[61]

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Tuticorin traders and legal professionals formed the core of the company and were its chief promoters. Needless to say, they could have hardly